

this is what it took.

I have been away from my family for six months, busy in a training camp, and just grafting. There were times when I couldn't be at my kids' birthdays, and it was hard. But I knew it was worth it because this is an opportunity, and I was determined to make the most of it.

What was the toughest phase of your career?

In my athletics career, probably the toughest moment was not making the final at the Beijing Olympics. But then, the joy of winning in front of your home crowd (in London, 2012), with 75,000 people cheering for you, was incredible. No amount of money, nothing, could buy that feeling. It was this feeling that drove me every time I doubted myself.

You were sixth in the World Youth Championships and 10th in the World Juniors. What aided your transition to the senior level?

All the races helped me gain experience and deal with challenges. As a junior athlete, I was good enough. I went to the World Juniors and finished 10th, but for me, the biggest challenge was trying to break into the senior level. That was challenging because when you are a junior, you have the talent and you can get away with it. But when you become a senior, you almost have to have the talent and be willing to understand and train even harder.

At that point, a lot of it was really trying to learn from my opposition, learn from the best guys. I had the chance to live with Kenyan athletes, and I learned a lot from them, in terms of how they would just eat, sleep, and train.

And, I realised that if I wanted to be as good as them, this is what I needed to do.

Questions have been raised by athletes about the popularity of track athletics. What could be done to make the track more popular?

We need to make it exciting. We need a lot of great athletes to create and participate in exciting events. Considering the population of India,



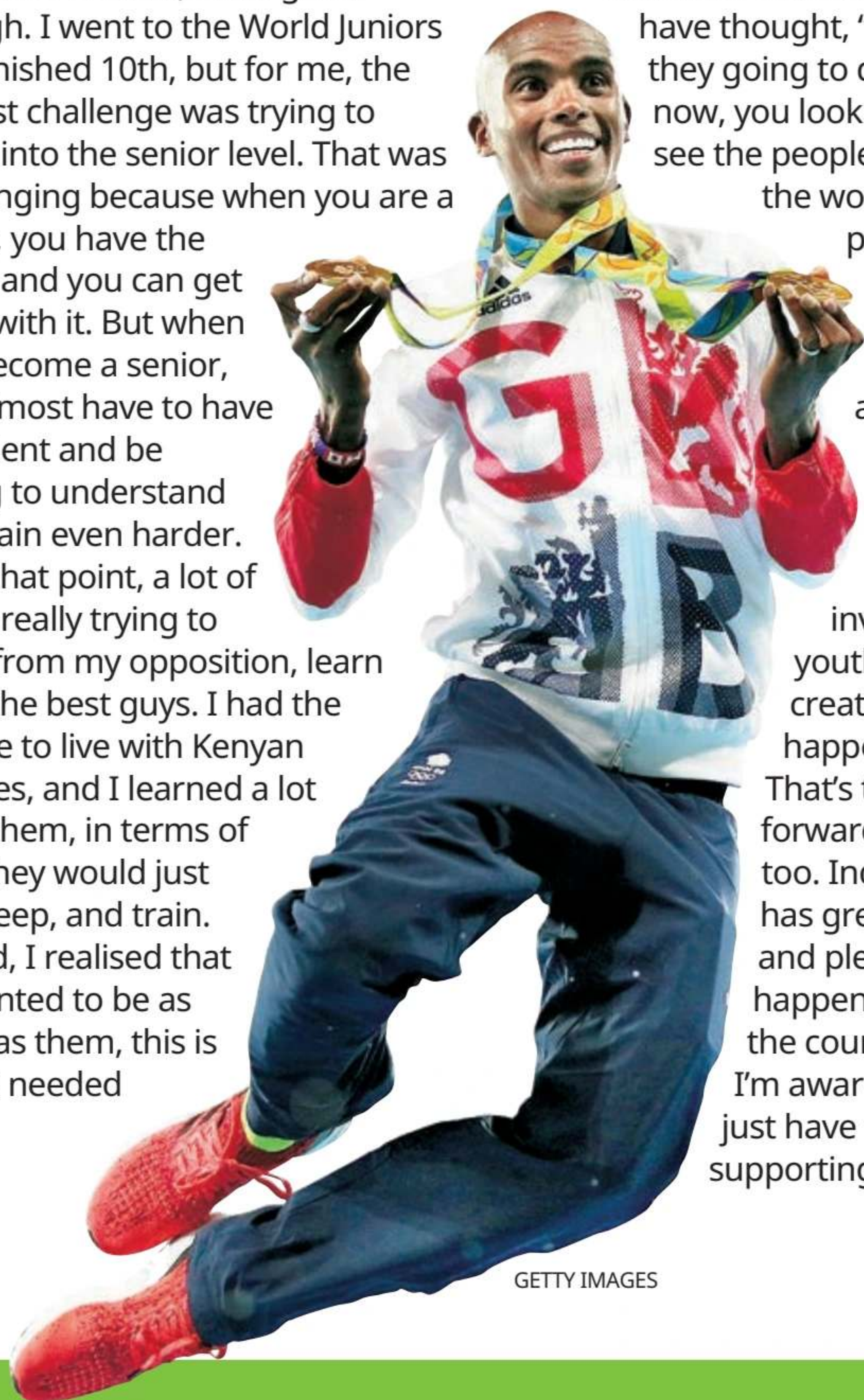
MY STORY – HOW I ARRIVED IN A NEW COUNTRY, WAS TRAFFICKED INTO THE UK, AND ALL THE CHALLENGES I HAD TO OVERCOME – SHOULD SERVE AS AN EXAMPLE FOR MANY



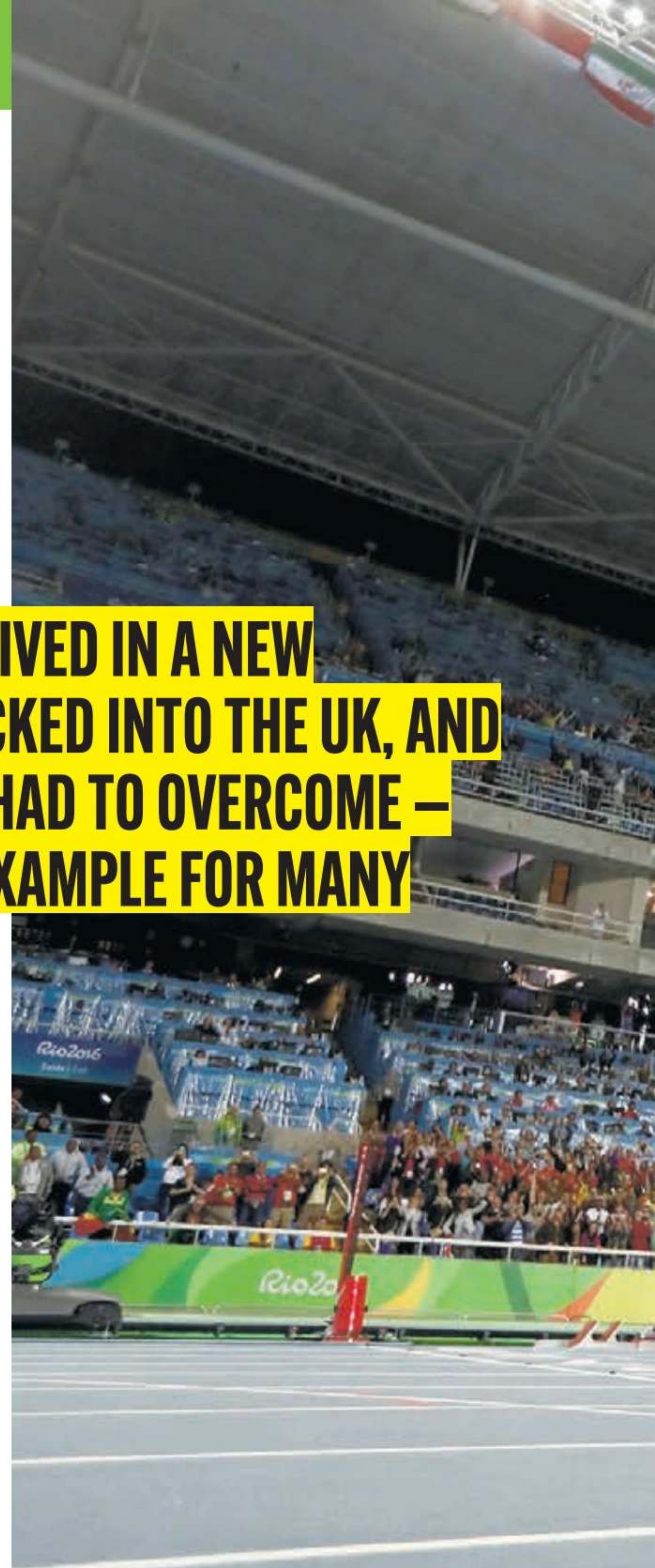
there are so many people here. I would love to see them roll, get the talent, and organise events for them annually.

We are here to celebrate the Tata Mumbai Marathon, the 20th edition. If we go back 19 years ago, in the streets of Mumbai, you would have thought, "Oh, how are they going to do it?" But now, you look at it and you see the people coming out, the women taking part, and you're like, "Wow!"

That alone should answer everything, because we need to invest in the youth, and try to create events that happen regularly. That's the way forward for India too. India already has great athletes and plenty of events happening across the country, which I'm aware of, but we just have to keep supporting the



GETTY IMAGES



youngsters. We need to inspire them, keep talking to them, and that really helps.

When I look at the Kenyans or someone like Paul Tergat or Haile Gebrselassie, I also feel inspired to be on the same journey as theirs. Even though you see them on TV, just remember, they took the same journey you are taking. They too had similar doubts that you are having, yet they got through it. That should motivate the youngsters.

You mentioned spending a lot of time with the Kenyan athletes. How was that experience?

It was an amazing experience, it's something that I had to do if I wanted to be the best. I was in the